



TED TALKS

The Official TED Guide to Public Speaking

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The Big “So What”



Great talks can inspire, educate and transform people. In this book, the head of TED, a world-renowned media organization, presents various [insights and tips that anyone can use to improve your public speaking skills](#).

Introduction



Great talks can spread powerful ideas, allowing you to inspire people, share knowledge/insights and spread your vision. When you combine public speaking skills with the power of the internet, you can multiply your reach and impact large numbers of people.

Public speaking makes everyone nervous to some extent. The good news is, [presentation literacy can be learned](#). There are many skills and tools you can master to make your talks great. Many famous personalities like Eleanor Roosevelt, Warren Buffett and Princess Diana all started out being terrified of public speaking, but managed to overcome their fears or even harness it to improve themselves.

Anderson recommends that you [treat the tips in this book as tools \(not rules\) to develop your own unique style of public speaking](#). In this summary, we'll cover the key ideas in 4 parts:

- Start with the right foundations
- Develop your ideas
- Preparation
- Delivery time!

KEY QUOTES

“Public speaking is the key to unlocking empathy, stirring excitement, sharing knowledge and insights, and promoting a shared dream.”

“Presentation literacy isn’t an optional extra for the few. It’s a core skill for the twenty-first century.”

“There are hundreds of ways to give a talk, and everyone can find an approach that’s right for them and learn the skills necessary to do it well.”

Part 1: Start with the Right Foundations



Your Idea: the crux of your talk



The most crucial thing in a great talk is to have an idea you care about that's worth sharing.

- An idea doesn't have to be an invention or something ground-breaking. It can be anything that changes how someone sees the world, be it a how-to tip or a reminder of what truly matters.
- Don't underestimate the value of your work, learning or insights. The truth is, every one of us has worthy insights based on our unique experiences. Take the time to reflect on your personal journey, your unique insights and what you truly care about.
- When you share an idea that changes others' mental models, you're giving them a lasting gift. That should be the essence of a great talk.



Whether you already have an idea you wish to share or just a hazy concept that needs to be developed, you must commit yourself to researching and building the idea before you're ready to share it. Anderson urges you to start taking action now to define your idea.

Build your Throughline



A throughline provides a core theme that connects all the components of your talk into a coherent overall picture.

- All great movies, plays or novels have a throughline. It's like having a rope where you can hang each new element that you present, or having a path upon which the audience can follow you to a specific destination.

KEY QUOTES

"The only thing that truly matters in public speaking is... having something worth saying."

"Your number one mission as a speaker is to take something that matters deeply to you and to rebuild it inside of the minds of your listeners. We'll call that something an idea. A mental construct that they can hold on to, walk away with, value, and in some sense be changed by."

- A throughline is more than a topic: it gives people something to think about and should be captured in no more than 15 words, e.g. “More choice actually makes us less happy”. Find your throughline, then build your talk around it. Your goal is to help the audience to understand that line thoroughly without any big leaps or mental gaps.

 **Developing your throughline.** Most speakers complain that they have too little time for what they want to say. The *wrong approach* is to put down everything you want to cover then try to compress it. The *right way* is to:

- Define 1 core idea, then take the time to show why it matters to your audience and flesh out each point with facts, stories and examples.
- Structure your talk such that every element is linked to and builds up your core idea. Commonly used structures include:

(i) What → So what → Now what

(ii) Intro → Context → Key concepts → Implications → Conclusion

Approach it Right



Great public speaking doesn't come from following a fixed formula or trying to be someone else. It's about being authentic; be who you are and go for a topic you truly care about.



The best way to communicate an idea is to recreate the idea in your audience's minds. This requires that you begin where the audience are and bring them on a journey with you.

- Use your audience's language, down to the examples and terms that they can relate to. For example, most people can imagine an elephant but not a *Loxodonta* (an elephant's scientific name).
- Pay attention to your choice of words, body language and tone of voice. They are all vital to your talk.

KEY QUOTES

“The secret of successful talks often lies in what is left out. Less can be more.”

“Your goal is not to be Winston Churchill or Nelson Mandela. It's to be you.”

 Avoid these 4 common mistakes. Do not:

- Make a sales pitch. Your role as a speaker is to give to the audience, not take from them. Even if you can get away with subtly promoting your products/services, try to avoid that. Focus fully on helping the audience to learn something meaningful.
- Ramble pointlessly. When you ramble on and on without a clear message or takeaway—or worse, tell the audience that you didn't prepare—you are being disrespectful of their time.
- Bore them with company talk. People who don't work in your organization aren't interested in your mission, products or milestones. However, they'd probably want to hear about the ideas behind your work, the surprising lessons you learned from overcoming certain challenges and how they can apply such insights to their own work.
- Put on an inspiring act. Many speakers try too hard to be adored by the audience; they focus more on putting on a show rather than delivering a great idea. Real inspiration doesn't come from a great performance; it comes from acts of courage, authenticity, selflessness or wisdom.

Part 2: Build your Idea



Once you have a throughline, you can start to build the elements to hang on it. In this section, we'll present 5 core tools you can use.

Connection



Before you can build an idea in someone's mind, you need their trust and permission. Talks are powerful because of the potential for human connection. When you build a bond with the audience, they'll be more open to what you have to say.



Make eye contact from the start. As you walk onto the stage, focus on your passion and excitement for what you're about to share. Then, take a few moments to look at members of the

KEY QUOTES

"You want to build your reputation as a generous person, bringing something wonderful to your audience, not as a tedious self-promoter."

"An organization is fascinating to those who work for it—and deeply boring to almost everyone else."

"Inspiration is like love. You don't get it by pursuing it directly."

"To make an impact, there has to be a human connection."

"Eye contact, backed by an occasional warm smile, is an amazing technology that can transform how a talk is received."

audience in the eye before starting your talk. This creates a real connection and syncs your mind with the audience's.

 Don't be afraid to show your vulnerability; it makes you real to the audience and they're even more likely to root for you. However, don't fake vulnerability just to manipulate others, nor share things that you yourself haven't yet worked through yet.

 Use laughter—it reliefs tension, warms the audience up to you and makes them more willing to listen to you. However, if you're not naturally funny, don't pretend to be funny or use tacky jokes from the internet. Try these tips instead:

- Use real anecdotes that're relevant to your subject but exaggerate or remix them in a fun way.
- Prepare a funny remark in case you make a blunder or face a technical glitch.
- Build humor into your visuals or create a contrast between what you're saying and what you're showing.
- Use satire, i.e. say the opposite of what you mean then reveal your true intent.
- When there's a laughing moment, pause to give people a chance to laugh (but don't try to fish for an applause).

 Shelf your ego. Unfortunately, it's hard to realize when we're being egoistic. Check that you're not name-dropping or boasting about your achievements, and test out your talk on someone you trust.

 Tell stories about your authentic personal experiences or people close to you. These can be used in any part of your talk—be it in the opening, middle or end.

Narration



Since the days of our cavemen ancestors, **stories have been used to bring people together, help people to dream, imagine, connect and understand one another.**

KEY QUOTES

"Humor is a skilled art, and not everyone can do it. Ineffective humor is worse than no humor at all."

"Self-deprecation, in the right hands, is a beautiful thing."



Wrap your story around a core idea and make it compelling with 4 components:

- Build it on a character your audience can relate to or care about;
- Build up tension using mystery, drama or danger;
- Use the right amount of detail—give just enough to let people imagine the scene vividly and remove the rest.
- End with a proper resolution that's surprising, insightful, funny or moving, and ties in with your core message.



You can also create your own parable (i.e. a short story that conveys a moral or spiritual lesson) but make sure you use analogies that your audience will understand.

Explanation



Understanding must be built like a hierarchy, with each layer constructed on a previous one. If you need to explain something complex or technical, always start with what people already know and build from there.

- Start where the audience is. Don't assume they're familiar with your topic and technical jargons.
- Spark their curiosity. Share something that makes them wonder "why" or "how".
- Then, introduce the related concepts one by one like building blocks and show how they're linked together.
- Use metaphors to draw a parallel between what you're explaining with something that the audience already understands (e.g. "the pre-frontal cortex of your brain works like a flight simulator to let you imagine things").
- Use short examples to help the brain apply the idea to a scenario to lock in the understanding.

KEY QUOTES

"If you're going to tell a story, make sure you know why you're telling it."

"In the right hands, a parable can entertain, inform, and inspire all in one."

"You can't give a powerful new idea to an audience unless you can learn how to explain."

"Knowledge can't be pushed into a brain. It has to be pulled in."

"Explanation is the act that consciously adds a new element to someone's mental model or reorders existing elements in a more satisfying way."



When you help someone to understand a concept, you fundamentally change their mental model and create a lasting impact.

Persuasion



Sometimes, before you can explain a new idea, you need to first demolish existing concepts that are wrong. **Persuasion is about getting the audience to realize that their current view of the world isn't quite right, so they're open to an alternative viewpoint.**



You can prime or nudge someone in a certain direction by using metaphors to make an idea more plausible.



Once someone is primed, it's easier to present your argument using reasoning.

- Break down your argument into a series of if-then statements. Start with something the audience accepts as true (or was proven to be true earlier in the talk), then build an argument like this: If X is true, then Y must happen, since every X implies a Y.
- You can also use reductio ad absurdum, i.e. give credibility to your position by presenting the opposite to your argument which is obviously false.



Use a detective story: present a mystery, the possible solutions, then eliminate the options one by one with the audience until there's only 1 logical conclusion. Bring the audience on a learning and discovery journey so they can persuade themselves.



Go beyond logic. Use humour, anecdotes, vivid examples, third-party validation and impactful visuals so your conclusion isn't just logical but also meaningful and energizing.

Revelation



The most direct way to convey an idea is to simply show it. You can mix and match 3 approaches below to lead up to a sensational revelation.

KEY QUOTES

"Our minds need to be primed before they can be persuaded."

"If you can walk someone through a reasoned argument convincingly, the idea you have planted in her mind will lodge there and never let go."

- If your work involves strong visual components, it can be very effective to take the audience on a “wonder walk” by taking them through a series of impactful images or videos. Don’t try to describe the visuals. Instead, focus on linking them to your throughline, e.g. explain the creative process or insights behind the work.
- If you’re sharing a new technology, process or invention, a demo is one of the most effective ways to show how it works. Don’t be afraid to add some showmanship like how the iPhone was launched.
- Humans have a unique ability to imagine what doesn’t yet exist. Using sketches, images, demos, or even a vivid description, you can build such a compelling dreamscape of the future that people will desire it. It helps to link such visions back to hope, humanity and/or actionable steps.

Part 3: Prepare, Prepare, Prepare



Use Visuals Effectively



✓ Visuals (photos, illustrations, graphs etc.) are not always essential and bad slides can actually hurt your talk. Use visuals only if they’re truly necessary and will make your talk more effective.

✚ Generally, there are 3 ways to add value with visuals:

- Reveal something that’s hard to describe in words. Let the visuals do the work so you can focus on setting the context and priming the audience.
- Explain or enhance your show-and-tell. Make sure what you say and show are in sync. Limit each slide to 1 core idea with only a short phrase, question or an image. Your slides should build curiosity, not steal the thunder by showing the words you’re going to say. When you’re not referring to a slide, switch to a blank screen so the audience can focus back on you.

KEY QUOTES

“(Dreams) can spread to others, build excitement and belief, and thereby make themselves come true.”

“Having no slides at all is better than bad slides.”

“The main purpose of visuals can’t be to communicate words... It’s to share things your mouth can’t do so well.”

- Delight your audience by adding aesthetic appeal. You do not have to explain every image you show.



The book includes many presentation tips on software, fonts, legibility, to-dos and not-to-dos. Here are some examples:

- Be original. Avoid standard presentation templates.
- Use high-res images on black background for the best effect.
- Use 1 simple, easy-to-read typeface per presentation, with ≤ 3 font sizes and at least 24pt-size for all fonts. Avoid using italics or underline as they're hard to read (bold fonts are ok).
- Build up the content on each slide by adding words and images progressively.
- Use videos only if essential and keep them to <30s each.
- Don't use flashy transitions or animations that distract the audience from your content.
- Send your presentation in advance and save a backup copy of the presentation, fonts, videos etc. in a zipped folder in a USB drive.

Scripting



In the past, TED tried to set rules, such as no lecterns or reading from a script. They've since realized that it's best to let speakers do whatever they feel most natural and confident with. **One of the key decisions you must make is whether to use a script.**



Scripted talks can help you to make the most of your time on stage. However, you must deliver it the right way to avoid losing passion and connection. There are 3 key strategies you can use:

- Know the talk so well that it doesn't seem scripted. This means you must practice *a lot*, until you know the material inside-out and are unlikely to freeze on stage. At the same

KEY QUOTES

"The key is to find the mode you can feel confident about, and commit to it."

"It's all about giving meaning to the words as you speak as naturally and passionately as you can."

time, the talk must come across as if you're sharing the ideas for the first time rather than reciting them from memory.

- Refer to the script from a lectern, screen or confidence monitor, but look up during every sentence to make eye contact with the audience so you're still speaking to them (not just reading).
- Reduce the script to bullet points and express each point in your own words.



Unscripted talks tend to sound fresh and real because you're thinking aloud and searching for the words in the moment. However, you still need to prepare for them.

- Prepare a clear talk structure and mentally label each set of points or notes you intend to cover.
- Prepare for potential problems so you know what to do if you can't find the words in the moment, if you leave out something critical or over-run your time slot.

Rehearse



Regardless of whether you choose a scripted or unscripted approach, you must rehearse repeatedly. **Your goal is to know your talk so well that you can focus fully on the meaning you wish to convey.** Rehearse in front of the mirror, to friends and family, to a group or just before you sleep. Insist on honest feedback on all aspects of your talk, e.g. whether you made eye contact, captured their attention, or helped them understand a new idea.

Open and Close



Even if you're not using a script, it's a good practice to **memorize the opening and closing lines for your talk to create the most impact.**



Here are 4 ways to start strong and capture people's attention from the onset.

- Use a little drama, like the opening of a great movie or novel, to make people curious about your talk. It could be a

KEY QUOTES

"When people think a talk sounds rehearsed, the problem is not too much rehearsal, it's too little rehearsal."

"In the opening sentences your sole goal is to give your audience a reason to step away from their comfort zone and accompany you on an amazing journey of discovery."

shocking fact (e.g. “In the next 18 mins as I give this talk, 4 Americans will die from the food they eat.”), a vivid story or a humorous line.

- Spark curiosity by asking a surprising question (e.g. “How did a 10-year old with only \$300 get an entire town to change their future?”). Or, frame your topic in an unexpected way.
- Use an impactful visual or object. A stunning image will capture attention, but when you can reveal something surprising about it, it creates an even bigger impact. You can also use openings like: “this video I’m about to show changed my life” or “I’m going to show you something that may seem impossible at first glance”.
- Use a teaser that gives a sense of where you’re at and where you’re going. But, never give away the punchline or the big reveal right at the start.



How you end your talk can shape how people remember the entire experience. Here are 7 ways to end powerfully.

- Pull back to show the big picture and the range of implications and possibilities of what you’ve just shared.
- Give a specific call to action and nudge your audience to act on the powerful idea you’ve just shared.
- Make a personal commitment on what you are doing to do.
- Create a vision of what the future might be.
- Ask a surprising question that makes people think about what you’ve said.
- Use narrative symmetry by linking back to something you’ve said in the beginning.
- If you’ve built up your talk properly, you can end with poetic language that evokes feelings about humanity, hope etc.

KEY QUOTES

“Curiosity is the magnet that pulls your audience along with you.”

Part 4: Delivery Time!



What to wear



The right clothing can help you feel good and connect with the audience. **Wear something you feel confident in and expresses your personal style.** Pick out your attire in advance to avoid added stress on the day of the talk.



When selecting your attire, consider these tips:

- Dress a notch above what the audience will be wearing.
- If you'll be filmed, avoid full white/black or small/tight patterns.
- Wear something that stands out on the stage and gives you a nice silhouette (fitted but not too tight). You can add a splash of color (e.g. a bright scarf) to go with neutral colors.
- Avoid dangling earrings and flashy/noisy accessories.
- If you'll be wearing a mike, wear a belt or a defined waistline to attach the battery pack.
- Rehearse your talk in the planned outfit.

Mental preparation



- Manage your anxiety and redirect the adrenaline to energy:
 - Use your fear as a motivator to practice as much as you can.
 - Before going on stage, breathe in deeply and release your breath slowly. Remember, it's ok to be vulnerable and show that you're nervous.
 - Eat a small portion of healthy food an hour before going onstage; avoid an empty stomach or eating too much.

KEY QUOTES

"Your clothing can earn you an audience connection before you've even spoken a word."

- Drink water (about 1/3 of a bottle) *just* before you go on stage so your mouth won't get dry.
- Identify a few friendly faces in the audience and focus your talk on them.
- Have a backup plan for common problems like forgetting your script, technology glitch etc.
- Remind yourself that what you're sharing matters and focus on sharing it.

Setup



Ideally, you should give your talk without a lectern and with at most notecards that you can hold in 1 hand. However, go with the mix of props and tools that works best for you and practice with them.

- If need be, have a comfort backup by putting your full script on a table or lectern at the side/back of the stage. That way, you can take a sip of water and review your script if you really blank out.
- Plant certain images or words in your slides as memory cues.
- Prepare 5x8 inch hand-held note cards; hold them together with a ring clip in case you drop them. Ideally, you should use them only occasionally and focus on the audience.
- Confidence monitors are available in certain venues, though you shouldn't over-rely on them. Never read off the monitors.
- If you must have your full script or laptop in front of you, ask for a sleek, unobstructive lectern that doesn't block your body.

KEY QUOTES

Voice and Presence



Talks are more powerful than written words alone because of your presence and connection with the audience. Keep practicing, and you'll eventually find your unique, authentic way of delivering the talk.



Vary your voice to match the meaning you wish to convey. Go through your script and highlight the key words, questions and moments. Try reading it with different nuances; experiment with pauses and changes in tone, pace, volume, rhythm and timbre. Use your natural, conversational pace as the default.



Body language. If you're not using a lectern, the simplest posture is to stand tall, place equal weight on both feet and use your hands and arms to amplify what you are saying. You can stand in 1 place or walk the stage so long as you're relaxed and deliberate with your movements.

Using Creative Formats



There are many other innovative ways to engage the audience's 5 senses and make your talk stand out. Just remember not to appear gimmicky or to lose sight of your real message.



Anderson shares many of such format innovations, including using dramatic props (like a real human brain or releasing a jar of mosquitoes), panoramic screens, multisensorial stimulation (like smells or tastes), live podcasting, dual presenters or debate formats, guest appearances etc.

Conclusion



- Anderson believes that public-speaking skills will become even more important in the future. He shares how TED is nurturing the talk renaissance, and urges every one of us to find and share our unique ideas to positively shape our world.
 - With the internet, it's now possible to learn from, understand and be inspired by people around the globe with totally

KEY QUOTES

"Talks can offer something more than the printed word... It's the human overlay that turns information into inspiration."

"Let's embrace the spirit of innovation...But let's also never forget that substance matters more than style."

"For the first time in history, it's possible for anyone on the planet who has access to the Internet to summon to their home the greatest teachers and inspirers."

different background, skills and experiences. This creates endless possibilities in terms of learning and innovation.

- o As the amount of information keeps growing and machines keep getting smarter, specialist knowledge is likely to become less valuable than *contextual knowledge* (the ability to see the big picture and how things fit together), *creative knowledge* and a deeper understanding of our *humanity*. Talks are a powerful means of expanding such knowledge and perspectives.
- As you pursue greater purpose and meaning in your life, you'll inevitably discover something worth saying. And, when you share such ideas with passion, conviction and authenticity in a connected world, there's no limit to the amount of impact you can make.
- In this summary, we've outlined the key ideas and tips in the book. The book also includes other tips and details, such as:
 - o Quotes, examples and snippets from various talks/ speakers; and
 - o Anderson's personal observations, beliefs and hopes for the future.

For more details, please refer to www.ted.com.

KEY QUOTES

"If we can find a way to truly listen to each other, and learn from each other, the future glitters with promise."

"Seeding a valuable idea... is the most impact that's possible for an individual to have. Because, in a connected world, that idea, once properly seeded, is capable of spreading itself."

"The future is not yet written. We are all, collectively, in the process of writing it."